rapidly and regularly obtain news or send orders on any matter touching the peace of his realm.' Along with fleet-footed runners, there were caravanserais and wells provided along these highways for the comfort of travellers.

At this time, in the clan of the Kachhwahas, with Raja Bhagwant Das at court, it was Kuar Man Singh who would now fly the white pennant of Amer on distant battlefields, including at Kabul. Having defeated the main Afghan and Pathan tribes in the area and taken Kabul, tradition has it that when Man Singh presented their multicoloured flags to Akbar, the Padshah allowed him the use of these colours as his own, to which Man Singh added the white of Amer thus creating the Dhoondhari 'panchranga' flag.

Besides the Kashmir and Kabul victories, Akbar's armies were active on other fronts. Raja Todar Mal, along with a large army, was sent to subdue the Yusufzai and avenge the unpardonable death of Raja Birbal. This indefatigable warrior built forts along the mountain passes and directed his forces to skirmish with the Afghans continuously till they were defeated. Raja Man Singh was dispatched to deal with the notorious Raushanias, a tribe of hillmen aiming to liberate Afghanistan from the Mughals. They were branded heretics, on account of the claims to prophethood of their leader, Bayazid, and 'were enslaved and sent to the markets of Central Asia for sale'. These emphatic actions taken by Akbar along the Hindu Kush were reason enough for Abdullah Khan Uzbek to send an ambassador, Sayyid Mir Quraish, to the Mughal court along with a selection of gifts including 'chosen steeds, powerful camels and swift mules; with wild animals and choice furs'. Much more effective a present, however, was a clutch of nine special pigeons from Turan along with Habib, a kabootar-baz. While the ambassador was kept waiting for an audience for many days, Akbar sent for Habib and his winged charges, was delighted with their exploits and wrote a thrilled letter to Abdur Rahim about the joys of ishq-baazi.

Sayyid Mir Quraish was kept for many months at the Mughal court, a virtual prisoner, but one who was extravagantly feted and dined. He was detained long enough to witness the victories of Man Singh against the Yusufzai and the victories of Bhagwant Das in Kashmir. He was then taken, along with the court, to Lahore, where he learned about the annexation of Kashmir. When he was finally allowed to leave in August 1586, along with the Hindustani ambassador Hakim Humam, Sayyid Quraish carried a letter